You don't feel like tramping over this marvellous carpet, but what to do? The tide will erase it all anyway, and the sand bubblers will start over tomorrow. Again, the forest walk runs right along the beach. A minute after you've heard the laughter of splashing children, you can be in a formidable, silent darkness watched over by gigantic trees, roots snaking at their base. Anchored in the underworld and touching the skies, they remind you why people first worshipped nature, and probably will again one day. The walk ends at Neil's Cove, where the rocks teem with lightfoot crabs, just visible as the sky goes aflame in pink and orange bands.

Snorkelling brings you closer to the uncounted life forms in the archipelago, and just off shore are some of the best diving spots in the world. Also on offer are kayaking for the adventurous and sunset cruises for the rest of us, and even an excursion to Barren Island, which has India's only live volcano. But it is a fragile and shifting ecosystem, the Andamans, and all our plans must stand ready to yield to weather and tide. Unless we plan to chill, in which case things will go like clockwork.

Tilar Siro means "earth from the sea" in the Great Andamanese language, and the resort follows the CGH Earth principles of sustainability and harmony with the environment. The artful but subtle architecture defers to the drama of the terrain. Deep balconies, hammocks, chaises by the pool, wood swings near the water, and convenient perches here and there let you enjoy the unmatched beauties of the island. A morning's bird-watching starts right on the property, where lily ponds and varied planting attract collared kingfishers, olive-backed sunbirds, glossy swiftlets, the Eastern yellow wagtail and the Andaman boobook, peering darkly down at us from the high branches of a tamarind tree. A bit further out one can spot the ashy drongo, the black-naped oriole, and the dusky-pink Andaman coucal. The scrawny Bay Island lizard scuttles on the tree trunks, and the shy emerald gecko slinks out of sight just when you try to take a picture.





EARTHY VIBES
Tilar Siro's artful but subtle architecture defers to the drama of the terrain

For all its peace and privacy, the resort is not isolated, and farm fields, markets and seafood shacks are all within a walk. The island was settled by Bengalis in the 1940s, some fishing along the coast and some farming inland, and the tiny temples here and there recall their native traditions. The cuisine is a mix of many influences from the eastern mainland, catering to the large numbers of tourists who now visit. Root vegetables, desi eggplants, and coconuts are augmented with produce from the mainland. At Tilar Siro, says GM Anil Kumar, they follow a simple rule, whether for meat, fish or vegetables: buy fresh, cook fresh, eat fresh. No frozen food is used, and the menu is written anew daily, depending on what was available in the market that morning. Slow cooking is the style here, to preserve the nutrients and flavours.

In the shade of these primaeval trees, and looking out on the white sand that is ever renewed and everlasting, it feels like slow is the flavour of the whole holiday.